

The Communication of 1 and 2 Peter: How Different Are They?

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Over time, the authorship claims of several New Testament books have come into question. Of all the letters attributed to Paul, only seven are considered by some scholars to be genuine. 1 and 2 Peter are among the other “questioned” letters. Who wrote these two letters? Did one person write both or was it two separate individuals? Both are attributed to Peter, but did he pen them, have them penned, or do they simply hold his authority? Richard Bauckham writes, “It can safely be said that if 1 and 2 Peter had been anonymous documents, no one would have thought of attributing them to a single author” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 145). But is Bauckham correct? While the question of authorship cannot be solved *solely* on the basis of the way both letters communicate, these two letters can be shown to be deeply connected in important ways which suggests they may be from a single source.

The Internal Similarities, Differences, and Connections

I. First Peter

Joseph Mayor notes that, “The style of 1 P. is clearer and simpler than that of 2 P., but there is not that chasm between them which some would try to make out” (Mayor, 1907, p. civ). He continues, “As to the use of the article, they [1 and 2 Peter] resemble one another more than any other book of the N.T.” (Mayor, 1907, civ). Mayor works through several more grammatical characteristics and notes that they are very similar to one another (Mayor, 1907, civ). Mayor does note, however, that 2 Peter is much more ambiguous and difficult than 1 Peter. Mayor concludes by stating, “On the whole I should say that the difference of style is less marked than the difference in vocabulary, and that again less marked than the difference in matter, while above all stands the great difference in thought, feeling, and character, in one word of personality” (Mayor, 1907, cv).

William Dalton shows how 1 and 2 Peter are connected by examining how 2 Peter interprets 1 Peter 3:19 and 4:6. Before he discusses those passages, Dalton convincingly shows, “Great similarity in ideas and structure between 1 Pet [3:13-4:11] and 2 Pet [2:1-3:18]” (Dalton, 1979, p. 551). Then, he turns to 1 Peter 3:19 and 4:6. Dalton notes that 1 Peter 3 is closely associated with 2 Peter 2 and that 1 Peter 3:19’s “spirits in prison” is parallel with “angels...committed...to pits of darkness” in 2 Peter 2:4. Dalton believes that 1 Peter 3:19-20 is a source for 2 Peter 2:4-5. 2 Peter 2:4-5 shows that 1 Peter 3:19-20 must be in reference to a proclamation to “sinful angels, a message that cannot be one of salvation” (Dalton, 1979, p. 553). Less convincing is his explanation of 1 Peter 4:6. He explains that this passage is connected with 2 Peter 3:7-12, stating that the “dead” in 1 Peter 4:6 are the Christians of 2 Peter, “Who accept the reality of the Lord’s promise ‘of new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells’ ([3:9-13])” (Dalton 1979, p. 554).

II. Second Peter

G. H. Boobyer discusses how 2 Peter is indebted to 1 Peter. Boobyer sees 2 Peter 3:1f as a reference to 1 Peter 1:10-12. He cites B. Weiss’ view that when it comes to general Christian teachings, ““No document in the New Testament is so like 1 Peter as 2 Peter”” (Boobyer, 1959, p. 35). Boobyer also cites Mayor’s list of parallels between the two letters: The Second Coming, Noah and seven persons being saved from the flood, μακροθυμία (“patience”) in 2 Peter 3:15 and 1 Peter 3:20, and “Prophecy as a divinely inspired foretelling of Gospel events now announced by apostles” (Boobyer, 1959, p. 35). Also, note the exact reduplication of 1 Peter 1:2 and 2 Peter 2:2: “χάρις ὑμῖν καὶ εἰρήνη πληθυνθείη” (Nestle-Aland, 2012, 1 Peter 1:2), translated, “Grace to you and peace be multiplied” (Young’s Literal Translation, 1997, 1 Peter 1:2). Boobyer notes that πληθυνθείη “As the verb of a NT formula of greeting occurs only in 1

and 2 Peter and Jude” (Boobyer, 1959, p. 39). Boobyer insightfully comments that in the pursuit of establishing authorship for 2 Peter, many have either overstressed the resemblances with 1 Peter or exaggerated the disconnections depending on who they believe wrote 2 Peter (Boobyer, 1959, p. 36). He goes on to note how 1 Peter 1:3-9 and 2 Peter 1:3-11 seem to be closely connected. While this connection seems less satisfactory, the other data he provides is helpful in showing some of the similarities between the passages. Besides those already mentioned, he also sees connections between 1 Peter 1:10-12 and 2 Peter 1:12-21, and 1 Peter 5:1 with 2 Peter 1:16-18.

Donald Guthrie provides a helpful analysis of Boobyer’s work. In one section, Guthrie examines Boobyer’s evidence that 2 Peter is literarily dependent on 1 Peter. Guthrie notes, “His [Boobyer’s] justification for maintaining a literary dependence is based on his acceptance of 2 Peter’s literary use of Jude” (Guthrie, 1990, p. 852). At this point, Guthrie presses, “His evidence here would equally well support the contention that the same author wrote both 1 and 2 Peter, for in that case we should expect the kind of parallels to which he refers” (Guthrie, 1990, p. 852). Then, he questions Boobyer’s view that 2 Peter is pseudepigrapha yet 2 Peter 1:12-13 overflows from 1 Peter 1:10-12. Guthrie asserts, “This could equally well have happened in the mind of one man through association of ideas, as in two minds with one drawing from another” (Guthrie, 1990, 852).

Richard Bauckham maintains that the two letters have different styles and vocabularies, which has been noted since Jerome (Bauckham, 1983, p. 143). Bauckham states that the most important differences in the two letters “Are not those of grammar and style but thought, themes, theological terminology...” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 145). For more of Bauckham’s observations, see *The Greek of 1 and 2 Peter* below.

III. Conclusion

There are many similarities and differences between these two letters. Boobyer is correct that both sides of the authorship debate surrounding 2 Peter must examine the evidence honestly and not overstate their case. It seems reasonable to state that these letters are correctly put side-by-side in the NT. At the very least, they share some of the same thoughts, subject matters, and other qualities mentioned above. Bauckham is correct that they use different terminology, but is different terminology sufficient evidence to suggest a different author? There are more similarities and differences to note that will help in answering the questions at hand.

The Greek of 1 and 2 Peter

I. First Peter

One of the most significant questions concerning 1 and 2 Peter is their different Greek styles and vocabulary. Often, the Greek of 1 Peter is deemed an “Elevated style of Greek” (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 125). Wayne Grudem rightly states, “The Greek may be said to be excellent, but to say it is a literary masterpiece is probably an overstatement” (Gruden, 2024, p. 7). The difference in the style of Greek of both letters is important but should be neither underplayed nor overstated. A balanced approach is necessary.

One of the most helpful works on the Greek of 1 Peter is Karen Jobes’ excursus in her commentary on 1 Peter. She evaluates the Greek of 1 Peter by using criteria of what would be usual Greek tendencies for a Semitic individual when writing Greek. These tendencies include things such as the way prepositions are used, the use of articles, and others, totaling 17 criteria. She notes, “Of the fourteen criteria relevant to 1 Peter, nine clearly fall on the side of the scale showing Semitic influence” (Jobes, 2022, p. 329). This demonstrates that 1 Peter may not be written by someone whose first language was Greek. Instead, it may be written by a Semitic

person (e.g., *possibly* a Jewish person). Although Jobes notes, “The style of 1 Peter, with its long sentences and rhetorical elements, may suggest someone who has a greater proficiency in Greek than would be expected of a Galilean fisherman. Nevertheless, Semitic interference is indicated...” (Jobes, 2022, p. 331). Because of Silvanus’ mention in 1 Peter 5:12 as a possible scribe, Jobes examines 1 Thessalonians (another letter noting Silvanus). What Jobes found was that 1 Thessalonians and 1 Peter are very similar in their use of Greek, both leaning toward Semitic influence. Jobes concludes, “The major conclusion drawn from this study is that the extent of Semitic interference in the Greek of 1 Peter indicates an author whose first language was *not* Greek” (Jobes, 2022, p. 334, italics added).

Michael Green is also helpful in evaluating the Greek of 1 and 2 Peter. Like Williams, Green notes that the Greek of 1 Peter is “Polished, cultured, dignified; it is among the best in the New Testament,” while 2 Peter is “Grandiose...like baroque art, almost vulgar in its pretentiousness and effusiveness” (Green 1987, pp. 23-24). He suggests that 1 Peter may be the work of Silvanus (Green, 1987, p. 24). Green states that 1 and 2 Peter have as many remarkable stylistic resemblances as they do differences. Both letters have “Strong Hebraisms and the striking habit of verbal repetition...these are features likely to have survived through the employment of different secretaries” (Green, 1987, p. 24). Green argues that while some of 1 Peter’s frequent words are missing in 2 Peter, “Others are replaced with synonyms” (Green, 1987, p. 24). Green cites several scholars who argue the similarities between 1 and 2 Peter. First, Joseph Mayor, who said, ““There is not that chasm between 1 and 2 Peter which some would try to make out;”” then, B. Weiss’ conclusion on a linguistic analysis, ““The Second Epistle of Peter is allied to no New Testament writing more closely than to his First;”” Next, Holzmeister, who “Showed that 1 and 2 Peter are as close linguistically as 1 and 2 Corinthians;” Then A. E.

Simms, who demonstrated that 1 and 2 Peter are as close “On the score of words used” as 1 and 2 Timothy (which have a unified author); and finally A. Q. Morton, who wrote that, ‘From cumulative sum analysis on the computer...1 and 2 Peter are indistinguishable linguistically’” (Green, 1987, pp. 24-25).

Joseph Mayor lists 3 comprehensive charts of the Greek words: (1) those used in both 1 and 2 Peter, (2) only in 1 Peter, (3) and only in 2 Peter. For words used in both letters, he totals 100. For words used only in 1 Peter, he notes a total of 369 (59 are *hapax legomena* (Greek words only found here in the NT)). For words used only in 2 Peter, he notes 230 (56 are *hapax legomena*). The final count is 100 words used in both and 599 that are not (Mayor, 1907, pp. lxxix-lxxiv). Mayor concludes that, “The Greek of the one is not by the same hand as the Greek of the other” (Mayor, 1907, lxxiv). However, as noted before, after a complete analysis of the Greek of both letters, Mayor notes that they are more similar than sometimes stated (see quote on previous paragraph).

II. *Second Peter*

Richard Bauckham states that 2 Peter “Must be related to the ‘Asiatic’ style of Greek rhetoric which was coming into fashion in 2 Peter’s time...with its love of high-sounding expressions, florid and verbose language, and elaborate literary effects” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 137). Bauckham questions if there are any “Genuine Semitisms” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 138). He concludes, however, “A native Semitic speaker cannot be ruled out” but suggests another possibility is “A native Latin speaker” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 138).

Bauckham also compares 2 Peter’s Greek with 1 Peter’s, much like Mayor. He states Holzmeister’s percentages: “38.6 percent [of words used in 2 Peter] are common to 1 and 2 Peter, 61.4 percent peculiar to 2 Peter, while...the words used in 1 Peter...28.4 percent are

common to 1 and 2 Peter, [and] 71.6 percent peculiar to 1 Peter” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 144). 1 and 2 Peter both have a large number of *hapax legomena*, showing that the author(s) had a wide vocabulary (Bauckham, 1983, p. 144). Finally, Bauckham states that the common words in both letters are “Mostly very common words” with only ἀπόθεσις being “Used exclusively in 1 and 2 Peter among the NT writings” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 144). While he deems the following list “Not very impressive,” he does share possible “characteristics” of words used in both letters: ἀναστροφή, ἄσπιλος, ἀρετή, and φιλαδελφία (Bauckham, 1983, p. 144). He also shows that the letters chose to use different words for the same idea. For the Second Coming of Christ, παρουσία is used in 2 Peter 1:16, 3:4, 3:12 and ἀποκάλυψις in 1 Peter 1:7, 1:13, 4:13 (and φανεροῦν in 5:4). Bauckham makes an important statement, “Of course, both letters are relatively short, are evidently directed to different issues and situations, and deal on the whole with different subjects.” However he goes on to state, “If 1 and 2 Peter had been anonymous documents, no one would have thought of attributing them to a single author” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 145).

Michael Green writes that 2 Peter has Aramaic thought behind it, footnoting Chaine, who lists a host of Semitisms behind 2 Peter (Green, 1987, p. 27, footnote 28). The footnote continues, stating that G. Wohlenberg suggested that 2 Peter may originally have been in Aramaic and then translated into Greek (Green, 1987, p. 27, footnote 28). Green also wrote an article titled, “2 Peter Reconsidered,” in which he notes some of the Hebraisms in the letter. He lists “φθοπᾶ φθαρήσονται, καταρᾶς τέκνα, and τοὺς ὀπίσω σαρκὸς πορευομένους” (Green, 1960, p. 11). He then says that the form of Peter’s name in 1:1 may be “A genuine Hebraism used by Peter himself” (Green, 1960, p. 14). If it is not, Green suggests an alternative that it is “A

brilliant archaism without parallel in the writings of the second century, including the whole corpus of pseudo-Petrine literature” (Green, 1960, p. 14).

III. Conclusion

The Greek of both letters is a complicated issue. However, at times there can be a temptation to overstate how different the Greek of these two letters are. The Greek of both is clearly different, however Bauckham’s note that they are short letters to different groups in different situations is important. In both letters, there seems to be signs of a possible Semitic speaker or at least influence and an overlap of some Greek words. While it is unclear if both letters come from a common source, the different style and word choice does not outweigh the possibility that the author of the letters simply made choices based on the need of his audiences, resulting in completely different letters. While this result seems far from satisfying on its own, it may be the case if other evidence works to show a common author.

The Use of the OT

I. First Peter

Karen Jobes wrote the entry on “1 Peter” in D. A. Carson’s *Dictionary of the New Testament Use of the Old Testament* (2023). In it, she notes that 1 Peter primarily quotes from the Septuagint (“LXX” used for the first five books. “Old Greek” is used for the rest of the OT). Jobes notes two primary purposes for 1 Peter’s use of OT: “To explain that Jesus was the Messiah, who, it was predicted, would suffer and die (prophetic interpretation)” and “To explain how Christian believers are to live out their new live in Christ” (Jobes, 2023, p. 594). Jobes notes that there are two OT sections that are prominent in 1 Peter: Psalm 34 (OG) and Isaiah, along with many other connections. See Table 1.

Table 1***1 Peter and the OT: Quotations, Citations, Allusions, and Influence***

1 Peter	Exodus	Leviticus	Psalms	Proverbs	Isaiah	Hosea	Other
1:1							Israelite Exile
1:2	24:3-8						
1:3			34:2 (33:2 OG)				
1:6			33:20 (OG)				
1:16		19:2					
1:17			33:5, 8 (OG)				
1:18			33:23 (OG)				
1:24-5					40:6-8		
2:3			33:1ff (OG); 33:9 (OG)				
2:4-8			118:22 (117:22 OG)		8:14, 28:16 (OG)		
2:6			33:6 (OG)		28:16 (OG)		
2:7			117:22 (OG)				
2:8					8:14		
2:9	19:5-6 (LXX)				43:4, 20-1 (OG)		
2:10						2:23 (2:25 OG)	
2:11			33:5 (OG)				
2:17			33: 10, 12 (OG)				
2:18-3:7					53:1ff		
2:22					53:9 (OG)		
2:23					53:7		
2:24					53:4-5 (OG)		
2:25					53:6 (OG)		
3:6							Abraham and Sarah (cf. Gen 18:22 LXX)
3:10-2			33:12-7 (OG)				
3:12			33:18 (OG)				
3:14-5					8:12-3 (OG)		
3:20-1							Noah and Flood
4:8				10:12?			
4:14					11:2		
4:18				11:31 (OG)			
5:5				3:34 (OG)			

Information from Jobes (2023, pp. 594-600).

Note: 4:8 and Proverbs 10:12 is marked with a “?” due to Jobes’ comment that this is probably not a quotation but rather Peter utilizing a “proverbial use” of the proverb “that was in circulation” at that time (Jobes, 2023, p. 597).

Jobes notes that 1 Peter’s use of the OT shows that he viewed the OT as authoritative and being fulfilled in Jesus (Jobes, 2023, p. 599). She also observes that the use of OT in this letter “Contribute[s] specific content to Peter’s thought, some of it distinctive and unique within the NT” (Jobes, 2023, p. 599). She makes two lists: “Contributions to Christology” (9 items listed) and “Instructions for Christian life” (12 items listed) (see Jobes, 2023, pp. 599-600). Jobes concludes with stating that the use of OT in 1 Peter is meant to “Orient its readers...to see themselves drawn by faith in Jesus Christ into the long and magnificent heritage of Israel” (Jobes, 2023, p. 600). Deeply connected are the sections on Jesus (Christology) and one’s new life in Jesus (paraenesis). Finally, in her commentary on 1 Peter, Jobes notes that 1 Peter is similar to Romans and Hebrews in OT reference frequency (Jobes, 2022, p. 46). Also, she mentions that at times 1 Peter quotes the LXX/OG exactly while other times it is slightly different forms of the text, possibly suggesting a different version was available to 1 Peter (Jobes, 2022, p. 47).

II. *Second Peter*

Matthew Harmon wrote the entry on “2 Peter and Jude” in D. A. Carson’s *Dictionary of the New Testament Use of the Old Testament* (2023). For 2 Peter, Harmon notes that the letter seems to, on some level, know Second Temple Jewish texts and traditions and uses them “Potentially in the way that... [2 Peter] interpret[s] OT texts” (Harmon, 2023, p. 412). Also, 2 Peter frequently refers to OT people and events without noting specific passages. Harmon states, “As a result, it can be difficult to determine the OT text form... [2 Peter] use[s]” (Harmon, 2023, p. 412). There are three main theological themes in 2 Peter: “The Word of God, God’s judgment

on his enemies and salvation of his people, and the return of Christ to consummate a new creation” (Harmon, 2023, p. 412). See Table 2.

Table 2

2 Peter and the OT: Quotations, Citations, Allusions, and Influence

2 Peter	Genesis	Numbers	Psalms	Proverbs	Isaiah	Habakkuk	Malachi	Other
1:11?								<i>Daniel 7:27 (OG)?</i>
1:17	22:2, 12, 16		2:7; 8:5 (8:6 OG)?		42:1			<i>Daniel 7:14?</i>
1:19		24:17-9	19:8; 37:6; 46:5; 130:6; 119:105, 130		9:2		4:2	Luke 1:78-9; <i>Song of Songs</i> 2:17?
2:2					52:5 (OG)			
2:4	6:1-4							Jewish Interpretations of Gen 6:1-4 (“e.g., Jub. 4:15-5:9; T. Reu. 5:6-7; T. Naph. 3:5” (p. 413))
2:5	6:17 LXX							
2:6-8	chs. 18-9 (19:29 LXX)							
2:15-6		chs. 22-4 (22:21-35)						
2:20-2				26:11				
3:5	1:1; 1:9-10		24:2; 102:25					
3:6								Noah and the Flood (cf. Gen 6-8)
3:7	9:11							
3:8			90:4 (89:4 OG)					
3:9, 12-4							2:3	
3:12					34:4 (OG); 60:22?			
3:13					32:16; 60:21; 65:17			

(OG)
(cf.
43:16-
21;
51:3;
66:22)

Information from Harmon (2023, pp. 412-415). Also, Bauckham's (additional) observations (discussed below) included in italics (see Bauckham, 1983, p. 138).

Note: Isaiah 60:22 marked with a "?" due to Harmon's comment that Peter may be drawing on Jewish tradition but still may be an allusion to Isaiah, noting some Jewish texts that connect the idea of "God hastening the end, sometimes in connection with Israel's repentance" (Harmon, 2023, p. 415). Observations from Bauckham (italics) which have "?" indicate possible (but uncertain) allusions.

Harmon concludes, "The frequently allusive manner in which 2 Peter... use[s] the OT assumes the reader is so familiar with those OT persons and events that even a name or a brief phrase is enough to evoke the entire OT context of that reference" (Harmon, 2023, p. 415). It seems to Harmon that 2 Peter does not so much directly quote (or cite) the OT as much as it does allude to and (potentially) echo it. Harmon notes that the main way that 2 Peter uses the OT is by blending "Analogies and typology, with the line between those categories not always clear" (Harmon, 2023, p. 415). 2 Peter uses "Stock-in-trade language from the OT" to describe false teachers (Harmon, 2023, p. 415).

Bauckham also lists possible allusions to the OT in his commentary on 2 Peter. See Table 2 above. He notes, "Unlike Jude, 2 Peter's allusions are habitually to the LXX" (Bauckham, 1983, p. 138). Bauckham then lists 2 Peter passages that "Correspond to the language of the LXX" (Bauckham, 1983, p. 138), including:

"1:11 (Dan 7:27 θ , LXX); 1:17 (Ps 8:6); 1:19 (Num 24:17); 2:2 (Isa 52:5); 2:5 (Gen 6:17); 2:6 (Gen 19:29); 3:12 (Isa 34:4); 3:13 (Isa 65:17). In the following cases the allusion is certainly not to the LXX version: 1:19 (Cant 2:17); 2:22 (Prov 26:11); 3:9, 12–14 (Hab 2:3); 3:12 (Isa 60:22), but in all except the first of these cases the author has probably taken the allusion from an intermediate source" (p. 138). These are found in Table 2 above.

Bauckham goes on to state that because of 2 Peter's familiarity with the LXX/OG, the phrases in the letter that are typical in the LXX/OG should be listed: “πορεύεσθαι ὀπίσω, 2:10; ἐπ’ ἐσχάτων τῶν ἡμερῶν, 3:3; ποῦ ἐστίν; 3:4” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 138). He also affirms that the author may be familiar with “Extrabiblical Jewish haggadic traditions (2:4-5, 7-8, 15-16)” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 138).

III. Conclusion

1 and 2 Peter are both full of OT references. There are a few overlapping OT references in these two letters. The clearest is Noah and the Flood (1 Peter 3:20-21 and 2 Peter 3:6). Both letters also have a (distant) reference to Isaiah 43 (1 Peter 2:9 with Isaiah 43:3, 20-1 (OG) and 2 Peter 3:13 with Isaiah 43:16-21). Another (distant) reference may be found in Israelite Exile in 1 Peter 5:13 with Daniel and 2 Peter 1:11, 17 with Daniel 7:14 and 7:27 (OG), but the 2 Peter reference is questioned by Bauckham (see above). There is also a connection in Genesis 18-19 (LXX) (1 Peter 2:9 with Genesis 19:5-6 and 2 Peter 2:6-9 with Genesis 19:29). In addition to these connections, both books cite from three of the same OT books: Psalms, Proverbs, and Isaiah. Outside of Isaiah 43, these books share no OT reference in these respective books. However, passages in Psalms and Isaiah that are referenced are near one another (see Tables 1-2 above).

Of interest is 1 and 2 Peter's commitment to the LXX/OG version of the OT. As stated above, Jobes and Bauckham note in their respective works that 1 and 2 Peter use this translation the majority of the time. The use of a single translation for most of the references in these letters shows another layer of similarity between these two letters. However, the LXX/OG was a common translation in the New Testament, so the connection here must not be pressed too far. If Jobes is correct that the readers of 1 Peter are supposed to see themselves as joining Israel's

heritage found in the OT, then the readers of 2 Peter have already done that, having become, in Harmon's words, "So familiar with those OT persons and events that even a name or a brief phrase is enough to evoke the entire OT context of that reference" (Harmon, 2023, p. 415).

The Gospels in 1 and 2 Peter

I. First Peter

1 Peter has several connections with the Gospels and their traditions. Before exploring them, there are a few things about the Gospels that must be noted. When a connection is identified between the Gospels and another writing, the key question becomes whether the author of the other writing (here, 1 Peter) knew what Jesus *said* or only what the Gospel author *wrote*. Some scholars do not believe the words of Jesus in the Gospels are his actual words, but simply what he either was believed to have said or what his teachings meant. This is called *ipsissima verba* ("the very words") and *ipsissima vox* ("the very voice"). Therefore, the question is often raised whether the connections in 1 Peter are to the written Gospels, their sources or traditions, or to Jesus himself.

Robert Gundry wrote an extensive article on the connections between 1 Peter and the Gospels. His connections are noted in Table 3 (see below). Of all the *verba Christi* (Jesus' words) in 1 Peter, "Only two are not directly related to gospel contexts in which the Apostle Peter plays a prominent part or would have had a special interest" (Gundry, 1966, p. 348). The two places are 1 Peter 1:8 with John 20:29 and 1 Peter 1:23-2:1 with John 3:3, 7. Gundry also qualifies that there are certain teachings in 1 Peter that could connect back to the Sermon on the Mount but because they are also taught in other NT epistles, they cannot be used to show a dependence on the Gospels and Jesus. However, the connections are still noted in Table 3 below.

I do not believe that all of the connections Gundry makes are necessarily accurate. It seems that one could make connections just about anywhere if one tries. Even Gundry himself says, “Several of the Dominical sayings reviewed... may be questioned” (Gundry, 1966, p. 348). However, his work shows that there are connections with the Gospels and Jesus’ teachings which cannot be overlooked. The presence of teachings from Jesus in 1 Peter which Peter himself was present for are significant. Gundry writes, “It is unthinkable that a pious forger who knew the gospel tradition cleverly inserted very allusive references to *verba Christi* from only those parts which Peter would most likely have remembered” (Gundry, 1966, p. 348). This gives weight to the pro-Petrine argument for 1 Peter.

Table 3

1 Peter and the Gospels: Connections, Allusions, and Influence

1 Peter	Matthew	Mark	Luke	John
1:3				3:3, 7
1:4			12:33	
1:6	5:10ff			
1:8				20:29
1:10-2			24:25f	
1:13		8:3	12:32, 35, 45	
1:21				14:1, 6
1:22				8:34f, 15:12
1:23				3:3, 7
2:1				3:3, 7
2:4, 7	16:18; 21:42	7:10		
2:9	5:16			
2:12	5:16			
2:13-7	17:26f			
2:18ff	5:10ff		6:27ff	
2:19f			6:32-5	
2:24				10:2-18
2:25				10:11, 14
3:8				13:5ff
3:14	5:10			
4:7		8:3; 14:32-42	21:31, 34, 36	
4:8				8:34f, 15:12
4:13f	5:10ff			
4:19			23:46	
5:2			12:32	10:11, 14; 21:15-7
5:3				8:4f
5:3-5	20:25-8	10:42-5	22:25-30	

5:4
5:8f

26:40

8:3; 14:38

22:31f

10:11, 14

Information from Gundry (1966, pp. 337-348).

Ernest Best, however, responded to Gundry (and others). He walks through many of the alleged connections and notes that the only connections that seem correct are blocks of texts in Luke 6 and 12 along with two isolated sayings: Matt 5:16 and Mark 10:45 (and possibly Matt 5:10).

Best makes an important observation: “Knowledge of the gospel tradition on the part of any author in the N.T. does not logically imply that he was present when that part of the gospel tradition was spoken by Jesus” (Best, 1970, p. 95). Paul, for example, knows of Jesus’ teachings but that does not mean he was necessarily with Jesus when he taught them.

It seems to me, however, that while Best is helpful in balancing the possible connections, he is sometimes unfair in his use of criteria, as Gundry notes concerning 1 Clement (see below). In one part of the article, Best states if Mark 10:45 was a true saying of Jesus, then 1 Peter 1:18 would be dependent on it, but since Titus 2:14 is closer to Mark than 1 Peter is, “We cannot conclude that the author of 1 Peter was present when the logion was spoken without suggesting that the author of Titus was also present” (Best, 1970, pp. 99-100). Here, Best overlooked that the author of Titus does not claim to be an eye-witness as 1 Peter does (by implication of its alleged author). Correctly, however, Best concludes that Mark 10:45 is probably a saying which 1 Peter uses.

Gundry responded to Best and pointed out issues with Best’s rebuttal. He stated that, “The standards by which allusions are judged genuine drop in the comparisons between *1 Clement* and Lk 6” (Gundry, 1970, p. 232). He also maintains that his thesis was not that Peter used the Gospels but that “He used traditions *deriving from his own memory* and independently written by others in the gospels” (Gundry, 1970, p. 221, italics added). While Gundry may draw

too many connections, Best appears to recognize too few. The evidence is best understood as lying somewhere between these two positions.

Thomas Lea gives an interesting case study of one instance of a possible connection between 1 Peter and the Gospels. Assuming Petrine authorship, he examines the use of what he calls “stone theology.” In 1 Peter 2:4-8, Peter uses three different words for “stone” (λίθος, πέτρα, and ἀκρογωνιάιον). Lea notes, “No other part of Scripture makes such extensive reference to stone and rock in relation to Jesus Christ as does this brief portion of I Peter” (Lea, 1980, p. 97). In this passage, Peter uses Psalm 118:22-23, Isaiah 8:14, and Isaiah 28:16. Lea suggests that Peter learned to use these passages from his time with Jesus, noting that Jesus himself used Psalm 118:22 in Matthew 21:42 (parallel: Mark 12:10-1 and Luke 20:17). Lea states, “In each reference to the Old Testament there is a close conformity to the text of the Septuagint in the portion quoted, and this distinctive quality is true also of the reference to the Psalm appearing in I Peter 2:7” (Lea, 1980, p. 98). Lea suggests that Peter would have been at this event to hear Jesus quote this Psalm. Interestingly, Peter also quotes the Psalm in Acts 4:11. Additionally, there is a possibility that Luke 20:18, directly following Jesus’ use of Psalm 118, could have influenced Peter’s mind to think of Isaiah 8:14-15 (Lea, 1980, p. 99). This to me, however, seems less likely.

Lea, importantly, acknowledges that there are other sources which use “stone theology,” such as Paul (see Romans 9:33 and Ephesians 2:20). Lea, therefore, says that it is possible Peter was “Influenced by these sources in addition to Jesus, or it is possible that all three may have their usage of stone theology traced to a common source” (Lea, 1980, p. 100). Finally, Lea notes that because of Peter’s nickname (“Πέτρος”) he would have been interested in “stone” and

“rock” motifs from Jesus. All this points Lea to see Jesus as a (likely) source for Peter’s understanding of these OT passages, especially Psalm 118.

II. *Second Peter*

Richard Bauckham notes four allusions (and other possible ones) to the Gospels in 2 Peter. See Table 4.

Table 4

2 Peter and the Gospels: Connections, Allusions, and Influence

2 Peter	Matthew	Mark	Luke	John
1:14				21:18
1:16-18	Closest (deemed an independent tradition); 16:28?	9:1?		
2:9	6:13?			
2:20	12:45		11:26	
2:21		9:42? 14:21?		
3:4		9:1 (parallel: 13:30)?		
3:10	24:43		12:39 (cf. 1 Thess 5:2)	

Information from Bauckham (1983, p. 148).

Note: Passages marked with a “?” Bauckham states are possible but not definite allusions and/or echoes.

Bauckham states the author of 2 Peter seems to know Gospel traditions independent of the Gospels we use. He continues on to say that of the four we use, Matthew is the most likely source.

Boobyer and Schreiner give even more possible allusions in their respective works. Boobyer notes the use of the word *ἐξοδος* in 1:15, which is the same word used in Luke 9:31 for Jesus’ departure (Boobyer, 1959, p. 45). Schreiner connects “honor and glory” (1:17) with the Transfiguration, suggesting that Jesus’ face was glorious (Luke 9:29, 32) and God’s message was honorable (Matt 17:5, Mark 9:7, and Luke 9:35) (Schreiner, 2003, 315).

III. Conclusion

Thanks to the work of these scholars, it seems that both epistles use either Gospel traditions or the Gospels more directly. Interestingly, both books have possible allusions from all four Gospels, showing at the very least a diverse understanding of the life and teachings of Jesus, although some are heavily disputed, as Best showed. Schreiner is helpful here, commenting that when evaluating 2 Peter and the Gospels, one must remember that if he was an eye-witness, he was recalling events from memory and not necessarily from the four written Gospels, but does suggest Peter may have relied on Matthew (Schreiner, 2003, pp. 315-316).

Notably, Mayor suggests that 1 Peter is written exactly how one would expect the apostle Peter to have written (Mayor, 1907, p. cxiii). He does not believe this holds true for 2 Peter. However, it seems that Mark 9:9 sheds light on 2 Peter 1:16-18. Jesus instructed Peter (and others) to not share their experience on the mountain until after his resurrection. Whether one believes this is historical or a literary device, it is interesting that the Transfiguration is not again mentioned in the NT until 2 Peter, a letter said to have been written by an eye-witness of the event. Either a clever reader of Mark saw the note and decided to use it as he embodied Peter, or Peter himself understood that now, years after Jesus' resurrection, it was appropriate for him to discuss such a powerful event in his life. The underlying connections to the Gospels in these two letters give support to an author well-developed in Jesus' teachings.

Paul in 1 and 2 Peter

I. First Peter

Travis Williams writes that there has been debate over if 1 Peter was directly influenced by Pauline letters (like Romans and Ephesians). According to Williams, the current consensus is that the similarities between 1 Peter and Pauline literature are because of “The use of common

tradition in early Christianity” (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 65). Williams and Horrell, therefore, believe that 1 Peter was not a “Quasi-Pauline document, standing firmly in Pauline tradition” (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 65) but rather used early Christian traditions. Williams continues, stating some of the similarities, differences, and connections between 1 Peter and Paul’s letters. Firstly, the opening and closing of 1 Peter seem to follow Paul’s pattern (however, there are differences). Such similarities are ἀπόστολος Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ (“Apostle of Jesus Christ,” 1:1) and χάρις ὑμῖν καὶ εἰρήνη (“Grace to you and peace,” 1:2). Williams notes that the following word in 1:2, “πληθυνθείη,” is “Unknown in the Pauline letters but found...in Jewish epistolary tradition...and in the greetings of Jude, 2 *Peter*, and 1 Clement” (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 67, italics added). Next, Williams notes the similarities between 1 Peter 1:3-9 and Eph 1:3-14. He also points out, “The most striking link with Paul is the exhortation ἀσπάσασθε ἀλλήλους ἐν φιλήματι ἀγάπης [‘Greet one another with a kiss of love’] (1 Pet 5:14), which is paralleled only, and almost precisely, in Paul (Rom 16:16; 1 Cor 16:20; 2 Cor 13:12; 1 Thess 5:26)” (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 69). He goes further, “There is a distinction between Paul’s holy kiss...and 1 Peter’s kiss of love...though this is hardly enough to establish the independence...of 1 Peter from Paul” (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 69). Williams concludes that there is likely “Some kind of Pauline influence on 1 Peter” (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 69). Then, Williams comments, “The particular formulation of paraenetical tradition found in 1 Peter seems to reflect Pauline influence” with Romans being a possible source for 1 Peter’s author (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 70). Williams footnotes a rebuttal against those who would reject any form of Pauline influence on 1 Peter and state that the only connection between them is common tradition. Williams challenges those who claim no literary relationship between Romans and 1 Peter, stating that if both Romans and the author of 1 Peter were in the

same place at the same time, why not see Romans to be a source for 1 Peter? Additionally, Williams sees a connection between 1 Peter 2:13-17 and Romans 13:1-7, noting, “1 Peter’s household-code teaching and exhortations about submission to the governing authorities seem to reflect the influence of Pauline tradition” (Williams and Horrell, 2023, pp. 71-72). There are also several parallels between the phrasing and terminology in both 1 Peter and Pauline literature such as ἐν Χριστῷ (“In Christ”) (1 Peter 3:16; 5:10, 14), which “Occurs...in the NT [outside Paul’s letters] only in 1 Peter” (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 72). For more, see Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 72. In conclusion, Williams states, “1 Peter shows clear signs of awareness of and dependence upon Pauline language and tradition” (Williams and Horrell, 2023, p. 73).

II. Second Peter

Richard Bauckham states that 2 Peter knew at least some of Paul’s letters because 2 Peter 3:15 calls them “Scripture” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 147). However, he goes on to say, “There is little sign of Pauline influence in 2 Peter” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 147). Bauckham includes Lindemann’s conclusion: “2 Peter is entirely uninfluenced by Pauline theology and contains no allusion to the Pauline letters” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 147). Bauckham gives the only allusions he sees as even possible: 2 Peter 2:19 with Romans 8:21 (cf. 6:16; 7:5), 2 Peter 3:15 with Romans 12:3 (cf. 15:15), and 2 Peter 3:10 with 1 Thessalonians 5:2. He says, however, “They are far from certain” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 147). It may be that 2 Peter did not see Paul’s work as relevant to his own, but this may be unsatisfactory as a complete explanation (Bauckham, 1983, p. 148). Bauckham offers another possibility: “The author’s theological thinking and terminology were formed before he had much contact with Pauline theology, and that a collection of Paul’s letters was only just coming into use at the time when he wrote” (Bauckham, 1983, p. 148).

III. Conclusion

1 and 2 Peter's relationship with Paul are clearly different. 1 Peter seems to be influenced by Paul, either by common tradition or Paul himself or both. There are several components of 1 Peter that remind the reader of Paul. The same cannot be said about 2 Peter. Interestingly, however, while 1 Peter seems influenced by Paul, it is 2 Peter that refers to him directly. It may be that despite Bauckham (and Lindemann) seeing it as very unsatisfactory, the reason for a lack of Pauline influence on 2 Peter is due to 2 Peter's focus—simply because he could have used Paul does not by necessity mean he had to. As Bauckman noted as a possible answer: 2 Peter could have developed his own respective theological thinking and terminology *before* he read much of Paul's work. If Petrine authorship is acceptable, then this possibility may be plausible. However, when it comes to 1 and 2 Peter and Paul, it seems that these letters are quite different in their relationship to him.

Analysis and Conclusion

From a careful study of the material presented here, these two letters seem to be closer aligned than Bauckham suggests (see Bauckham, 1983, p. 145). While they are by no means identical to one another in their presentation, style, vocabulary, or the like, they do share important similarities, such as the Semitic nature of both letters, use of OT and its characters and events, connection to the Gospels (both to Jesus' teachings and events involving Peter), and other general similarities discussed above.

While the question of joint authorship of these two letters cannot be finalized based solely on an analysis of their use of communication, it can be shown that these books are deeply connected in some important ways, which may lead the way to a "single-author" conclusion. There is more work to be done on the question of Petrine authorship, but these specific pieces of

evidence demonstrate that the relationship between the two letters is defined by more than their differences. Boobyer is correct: “The resemblances and differences between these writings seem to have been examined mainly...as an aspect...of the authorship [question] of 2 Peter. This may have led those concerned to establish a common authorship...to overstress the resemblances, whilst those convinced that the second was not by the same hand...could have exaggerated the disconnectedness” (Boobyer, 1959, p. 36). When the similarities and differences are evaluated, it is reasonable to accept the opening words of these letters as accurate statements about their author: “Peter, an apostle of Jesus Christ.”

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